

BOOK 1 OF THE HOLLOW DOMINION

# THE DREAMING GATE

A D&D 5e Adventure for Levels 1-3

3-4 Sessions | 3-5 Players

by **Helm Evans**

Tuco Enterprises



# ADVENTURE SUMMARY

A kingdom cursed by the death-throes of a dreaming god

## BACKGROUND

The players are drawn to the Hollow Dominion by a shared dream — a vision of a dying god calling for help. Upon arrival, they discover the kingdom is cursed by the death-throes of **Mordath, the Dreaming God**. The landscape warps unpredictably, nightmare creatures stalk the roads, and the populace is divided between those fighting to survive and those who've given in to madness.

The players discover they are **Dreambound** — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness, marked by a glowing sigil. They cannot leave until the curse is broken — and if Mordath dies without resolution, they die with him.

The adventure spans **three parts**: arrival at the Ashen Gate, investigation in the town of Drearym, and the climactic assault on the Gatehouse of Dreams. Along the way, the party must navigate faction politics, rescue the innocent, and uncover the truth behind the curse — all while the land itself tries to consume them.

| ADVENTURE DETAILS |                      |
|-------------------|----------------------|
| System            | D&D 5e               |
| Levels            | 1-3                  |
| Sessions          | 3-4                  |
| Players           | 3-5                  |
| Tone              | Dark fantasy mystery |
| Play Time         | 8-12 hours           |

| FACTIONS     |                            |
|--------------|----------------------------|
| Waking Guard | Soldiers maintaining order |
| Dreamseekers | Cultists seeking freedom   |
| Veil Court   | Surviving nobility         |
| The Unbound  | Nightmare-consumed victims |

## ADVENTURE HOOK: THE SHARED DREAM

"For three nights running, you've had the same dream. A vast chamber of white stone, a figure on a throne robed in starlight, its face hidden behind a mask of cracked porcelain. It speaks: 'Come. Please. Before it is too late.' On the fourth day, you each find a mark on your skin — a glowing sigil shaped like an eye within a crescent moon."

The sigil is the **Dreambound Mark**. It glows purple in darkness, burns near dream-energy, and cannot be removed by any means short of breaking the curse. NPCs in the Dominion can identify it immediately.

DM NOTE

The Dreambound Mark is both a curse and a tool. It allows the bearer to sense dream-energy (detect as a bonus action, 30ft range) but also makes them visible to nightmare creatures in darkness. Use this tension throughout the adventure.

PART 1: THE ASHEN GATE

The entrance to the Hollow Dominion — and the point of no return

DANGER ●●○○○

ARRIVAL

"The archway rises from the mist like a broken tooth. Once-grand stone, now cracked and leaking purple dream-energy that makes your sigil burn warm. Beyond the gate, trees grow sideways and the road shifts when you're not looking."

The Ashen Gate is the only known entrance to the Hollow Dominion. Passing through it is a one-way trip — the gate does not allow return travel. The purple energy is raw dream-stuff leaking from Mordath's dying mind. Characters who touch it must make a **DC 12 WIS save** or experience a brief, disorienting vision of Mordath's throne room.

ENCOUNTER: ELDON VOSS, THE GATEKEEPER

An old man in a tattered guard's uniform sits on a stone beside the gate, whittling a piece of wood. Half-mad but sharp. He looks up as you approach, eyes narrowing at your glowing sigils.

"You're Dreambound. Welcome to the nightmare, friends. Mind the roads after dark. Things come through from the Dreaming Depths when the sun goes down."

- ◆ The Dominion has been cursed for **six months**
- ◆ The landscape warps unpredictably — paths change, distances stretch
- ◆ **Nightmare creatures** emerge at dusk from thin points in reality
- ◆ The **Waking Guard** maintain order in Drearym; the **Dreamseekers** want Mordath dead
- ◆ "Don't sleep near running water — that's where the nightmares come through strongest."
- ◆ Three days' travel from the Gate to Drearym along the Twisted Road

ELDON VOSS — THE GATEKEEPER

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL GOOD

|     |     |     |     |     |     |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| STR | DEX | CON | INT | WIS | CHA |
| 10  | 8   | 12  | 14  | 16  | 11  |
| +0  | -1  | +1  | +2  | +3  | +0  |

**AC 11 | HP 18 (2d8+4) | Speed 30 ft.**  
**Skills:** Insight +5, Perception +5, Survival +5  
**Senses:** Passive Perception 15 | **Languages:** Common  
**Dreamsense.** Eldon can detect dream-energy within 60 feet. He knows the location of all nightmare creatures within range in darkness.  
**Fragmented Mind.** Advantage on saves against frightened, but disadvantage on saves against charm and illusion.  
**Actions:** *Club.* +2 to hit, 1d4 bludgeoning. *Information (1/day).* Eldon reveals one useful fact about the Dominion.

DM NOTE

Eldon was once a respected captain of the Waking Guard. The curse broke his mind but fragments of wisdom remain. Treat him with kindness and he's a valuable source of information — he knows the safe paths, the dangerous thin points, and the general layout of the Twisted March.

# THE TWISTED MARCH

Three days through nightmare-ravaged countryside

DANGER ●●●○○

THE TWISTED ROAD

The road from the Ashen Gate to Drearym is called the **Twisted March** — a three-day journey through forest warped by Mordath's dying dreams. Trees grow at impossible angles. Streams run purple. The distance between landmarks changes depending on the time of day.

**Travel Pace:** 12 miles per day (reduced from normal 24 due to warping). Each day, roll on the **Random Events Table**. At night, roll d6 — on 1-2, a **Nightmare Spawn** encounter occurs.

| RANDOM EVENTS (ROLL D8 EACH DAY) |                                                                                                                                                     |
|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| D8                               | EVENT                                                                                                                                               |
| 1                                | <b>Shifting Path:</b> Road doubles back. DC 12 Survival or lose 1d4 hours and 1 exhaustion.                                                         |
| 2                                | <b>Dream Echo:</b> Ghostly overlay of the Dominion before the curse. One player sees Mordath before he began dying. DC 13 WIS or 1 exhaustion.      |
| 3                                | <b>Nightmare Spawn:</b> A <b>Nightmare Wolf</b> (Wolf: HP 18, Bite +4, 2d4+2+1d4 psychic, immune to charm) attacks. Flees at half HP.               |
| 4                                | <b>Traveler:</b> Refugee <b>Pella Dunn</b> warns Dreamseekers are "harvesting" Dreambound. Fleeing to Drearym.                                      |
| 5                                | <b>Dream Shimmer:</b> One player phases into Mordath's dream. Sees white throne room, hears "Find the three keys." DC 14 WIS or 2d6 psychic damage. |
| 6                                | <b>Waking Guard Outpost:</b> 4 Guards offer rest, rations, and information about Drearym.                                                           |
| 7                                | <b>Thin Point:</b> Purple pool bubbles up. DC 13 CON or pulled into dream vision (lore/foreshadowing).                                              |
| 8                                | <b>Peaceful Stretch:</b> Warping subsides. Clean water, edible mushrooms. Recover 1 exhaustion, benefit of short rest.                              |

| NIGHT ENCOUNTERS (ROLL D6) |                                                                                                               |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| D6                         | ENCOUNTER                                                                                                     |
| 1-2                        | <b>Nightmare Spawn:</b> 1d4+1 Nightmare Wolves attack.                                                        |
| 3-4                        | <b>Dream Whispers:</b> Sleeping characters DC 12 WIS or no long rest benefit, 1 exhaustion.                   |
| 5                          | <b>Unbound Patrol:</b> 2 Unbound (Zombie stats, psychic damage, immune to sleep) shamble past. Stealth DC 13. |
| 6                          | <b>Quiet Night:</b> Distant purple glow on horizon — the Gatehouse of Dreams.                                 |

*"The land remembers what it was. Sometimes, at the edges of your vision, you can see it — green fields, blue sky, children playing. Then you blink, and it's all twisted again."*



# MAP: THE TWISTED MARCH

Regional map — Ashen Gate to Drearym



*The Ruined Tower of Valdris — a landmark halfway between the Ashen Gate and Drearym. Once a wizard's retreat, now consumed by dream-energy.*

## MAP KEY & LANDMARKS

- ◆ **Ashen Gate (South):** Entry point. Meet Eldon Voss. The point of no return.
- ◆ **Waking Guard Outpost:** Day 1. Safe haven with supplies and information.
- ◆ **The Wellspring:** Day 1-2. Ancient well leaking purple energy. Side quest: rescue Lissa Greel.
- ◆ **Ruined Tower of Valdris:** Day 2. DC 14 Investigation finds hidden journal page about Mordath.
- ◆ **Purple Pools:** Thin points between worlds. Nightmare creatures emerge after dark.
- ◆ **Drearym (North):** Day 3. First major town. Faction tensions.

# PART 2: THE TOWN OF DREARYM

A town on the edge of collapse

DANGER ●●●○○

## ARRIVAL

*"Drearym was once a prosperous market town of 2,000. Now it holds perhaps 800. A makeshift wall of sharpened logs surrounds the town. Purple mist hovers in the alleys. Some buildings lean at impossible angles. People eye your Dreambound marks with pity and suspicion."*

The town is under martial law. The Waking Guard controls the gates. The party's Dreambound marks will be noted — some townsfolk hostile, others desperate for help.

## KEY LOCATIONS

- 1. The Vigorous Dog (Inn)** — Run by **Marta Greel**, a former adventurer who lost her leg to a nightmare creature. Her daughter **Lissa** (16) went missing near the Wellspring. **50gp reward** for her return.
- 2. Waking Guard Barracks** — **Captain Rena Ashford**, stern but fair. Asks the party to investigate nightmare sightings (**30gp reward**). Warns about Brother Caelum.
- 3. Old Town Chapel** — **Dreamseekers** led by **Brother Caelum**. He preaches that Mordath's death will "free" the Dreambound. He's being manipulated by The Architect.
- 4. The Wellspring** — Ancient well outside the eastern wall, leaking purple dream-energy. Lissa was last seen here. Dangerous at night.
- 5. Market Square** — Central gathering place. Notice board with missing persons, bounties, Dreamseeker recruitment.

## FACTION: THE DREAMSEEKERS

The Dreamseekers believe killing Mordath will end the curse. They're **wrong** — it will kill every Dreambound, including the players. **The Truth:** Caelum is being manipulated by **The Architect** — an entity within Mordath's dreams that wants the god dead to consume his divine essence.

# MAP: DREARYM

Town map — Key locations and faction territories



*Drearym — A walled market town under siege. Purple water flows through the settlement. Waking Guard controls the north gate; Dreamseekers gather in the southeast chapel.*

KEY LOCATIONS

- ◆ **A — The Vigorous Dog:** Marta's inn. Safe haven. Rooms 5sp/night.
- ◆ **B — Waking Guard Barracks:** Captain Ashford's HQ. 12 Guards. Armory (locked, DC 15).
- ◆ **C — Old Town Chapel:** Dreamseeker meeting place. Secret basement ritual chamber.
- ◆ **D — Market Square:** Notice board. Refugee camp in eastern corner.
- ◆ **E — The Wellspring:** Outside eastern wall. Lissa's last known location.
- ◆ **F — North Gate:** Waking Guard checkpoint. Curfew after sunset.

# NPCS OF DREARYM

Key characters the party will encounter



Mordath — The Dreaming God, his divine form crumbling and leaking dream-energy into the mortal world.

CAPTAIN RENA ASHFORD — WAKING GUARD

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), LAWFUL GOOD

|     |     |     |     |     |     |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| STR | DEX | CON | INT | WIS | CHA |
| 16  | 12  | 14  | 10  | 14  | 13  |
| +3  | +1  | +2  | +0  | +2  | +1  |

AC 16 (chain mail) | HP 45 (6d8+12) | Speed 30 ft.

**Saves:** STR +5, CON +4 | **Skills:** Athletics +5, Intimidation +3, Perception +4

**Equipment:** Longsword, shield, chain mail, signal horn, 15gp

*Longsword.* +5 to hit, 1d8+3 slashing. *Signal Horn (1/day).* Summons 2d4 Guards in 1d4 rounds.

**Personality:** Stern, fair, exhausted. She's been holding the town together for six months. Respects competence, despises Dreamseeker rhetoric.

BROTHER CAELUM — DREAMSEEKER PRIEST

MEDIUM HUMANOID (HUMAN), NEUTRAL

|     |     |     |     |     |     |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| STR | DEX | CON | INT | WIS | CHA |
| 10  | 12  | 10  | 14  | 16  | 18  |
| +0  | +1  | +0  | +2  | +3  | +4  |

AC 13 (chain shirt) | HP 32 (5d8+10) | Speed 30 ft.

**Skills:** Deception +6, Insight +5, Persuasion +8, Religion +4

**Spellcasting (Cleric 5):** DC 13, +5 to hit. *Cantrips:* guidance, sacred flame, thaumaturgy. *1st (4):* command, cure wounds, sanctuary, shield of faith. *2nd (3):* hold person, spiritual weapon, augury. *3rd (2):* spirit guardians, dispel magic.

**Dreamseeker's Blessing:** *Detect thoughts* at will (bonus action). Granted by The Architect.

**Personality:** Charismatic, passionate, genuinely believes killing Mordath will save everyone. Being manipulated by The Architect.



# ENCOUNTER: THE DREAMING WELL

A thin point between worlds

DANGER ●●●○○

SETUP

The Wellspring is a thin point between the waking world and Mordath's dreams. **Lissa Greel** sits at the well's edge, eyes open but unseeing, trapped in a Dream Loop. **2 Nightmare Spawn** guard the well.

**Terrain:** Well is 10ft diameter, 15ft deep. Purple liquid fills bottom 5ft. Within 10ft = difficult terrain. Within 5ft = DC 12 WIS save or pulled 5ft toward well.

RESCUING LISSA — THREE OPTIONS

**Option 1 — Physical Pull:** DC 14 Strength (Athletics). Nightmare Spawn attack to prevent. Failure = DC 13 WIS or stunned until end of next turn.

**Option 2 — Enter the Dream:** Touch water, fail DC 13 WIS. Inside: sunlit festival, Lissa with her dead father. DC 13 Persuasion to convince her to leave. Failure = 2d6 psychic damage, ejected.

**Option 3 — Disrupt the Thin Point:** DC 14 Arcana. Success = Spawn take 3d6 radiant, Lissa freed. Failure = 2d6 psychic damage.

NIGHTMARE SPAWN

MEDIUM UNDEAD, CHAOTIC EVIL (RESKINNED SHADOW)

**AC** 12 | **HP** 16 (3d8+3) | **Speed** 40 ft.

**STR** 6 (-2) | **DEX** 14 (+2) | **CON** 13 (+1) | **INT** 6 (-2) | **WIS** 10 (+0) | **CHA** 8 (-1)

**Damage Resistances:** Acid, Cold, Fire, Lightning, Thunder; Bludgeoning, Piercing, Slashing from nonmagical attacks

**Damage Vulnerabilities:** Radiant (+1d6 from moonlight effects)

**Condition Immunities:** Exhaustion, Frightened, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Poisoned, Prone, Restrained

**Strength Drain.** +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one creature. Hit: 9 (2d6+2) **psychic** damage (not necrotic). Target's STR reduced by 1d4. If STR reaches 0, target dies and rises as Unbound in 1d4 rounds.

**Nightmare Aura:** Creatures starting turn within 10ft must DC 11 WIS save or be frightened until start of next turn.

**Amorphous:** Can move through 1-inch spaces without squeezing.

**Shadow Stealth:** In dim light or darkness, can take Hide action as bonus action.

DM NOTE

If a player enters the dream, they glimpse Mordath's throne room and three glowing keys: **Bronze** (The Architect), **Silver** (The Crown), **Gold** (The Heart). Foreshadows Books 2-5.

# PART 3: THE GATEHOUSE OF DREAMS

The boundary between worlds

DANGER ●●●●○

THE GATEHOUSE

A fortress built into a cliff face — the boundary between the waking world and Mordath's consciousness. Once a monastery, now a ruin consumed by dream-energy. **Four wings** connected by a central courtyard:

- ◆ **Dormitory (West):** Collapsed. DC 13 Investigation finds a **Journal Page** about Mordath's prophecy.
- ◆ **Library (North):** Lore about Mordath — he foresaw his own death. His curse is a divine fever dream, not malicious.
- ◆ **Chapel (East):** Veil is thinnest. 3 Nightmare Spawn emerge. DC 13 WIS or pulled into vision of Mordath pleading.
- ◆ **Gate Hall (South):** The Dreaming Gate — massive purple portal. Through it: Mordath's white throne room.

EXPLORING THE GATEHOUSE

**Central Courtyard:** Fountain of purple liquid. Drinking it (DC 15 CON) grants **Dreamsense** (60ft) for 1 hour but causes hallucinations (disadvantage on Perception).

**Dormitory Journal:** *"Mordath spoke to us in dreams. He said: 'I have seen my death. It comes not from enemies, but from within. The Architect stirs in my dreams.'"*

**Library:** *"The Dreaming God: A Theological History"* — Mordath was a mortal who ascended through collective dreams. The Architect is a fragment of his own fear of death that gained sentience.

**Chapel:** 3 Nightmare Spawn. Altar defaced with Architect's symbol (eye within spiral). DC 14 Religion to identify as corruption of Mordath's crescent moon.

THE GATE HALL — APPROACHING THE PORTAL

*"The Gate Hall opens onto the cliff edge. Before you stands the Dreaming Gate — a massive archway of white stone, thirty feet tall, filled with swirling purple energy. Through the portal: a vast white throne room. On the throne sits a figure robed in starlight, mask of cracked porcelain. The figure's chest rises and falls — barely. Dying."*

Between you and the portal stands a figure in purple armor, twin blades of crackling pink energy humming in its hands. It does not speak. But you feel its sorrow — a weight that presses against your chest like deep water.

BOSS: THE NIGHTMARE KNIGHT

Guardian of the Dreaming Gate

DANGER ●●●●●

**THE GUARDIAN**

The Nightmare Knight is a **Dreambound soul** — a former guardian who chose to protect the gate. It is not evil, merely bound by duty. It fights to prevent anyone from approaching Mordath, believing this will hasten his death.

**Social Encounter:** DC 15 Persuasion (DC 12 if Lissa was rescued). Success: it steps aside. "The god is dying. What you do in there will determine whether the Dominion lives or dies." Failure: it attacks.

**Combat:** Hard encounter for level 3. Knight fights defensively, pushing characters away from the gate. Surrenders at 20 HP: "You are determined. Perhaps... you are what he has been waiting for."

**NIGHTMARE KNIGHT**

MEDIUM UNDEAD, LAWFUL NEUTRAL

|     |     |     |     |     |     |
|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|-----|
| STR | DEX | CON | INT | WIS | CHA |
| 18  | 14  | 18  | 12  | 14  | 16  |
| +4  | +2  | +4  | +1  | +2  | +3  |

AC 15 (half plate) | HP 85 (10d8+40) | Speed 30 ft.

**Saves:** STR +7, CON +7, WIS +4

**Resistances:** Necrotic; B/P/S from nonmagical | **Vulnerabilities:** Radiant

**Immunities:** Charmed, Exhaustion, Frightened, Poisoned

*Multiattack.* Two Energy Blade attacks.

*Energy Blade.* +7 to hit, 2d6+4 slashing + 1d8 psychic.

*Life Drain (Recharge 5-6).* +7 to hit, 3d6+4 psychic, heals half.

*Dream Step (Bonus).* Teleport 30ft. No opportunity attacks.

*Parry (Reaction).* +3 AC vs one melee attack.

**Legendary Action (1/round):** *Reposition.* Move 15ft, no opportunity attacks.

**TOUCHING THE GATE**

"The world dissolves into white. You stand in a vast throne room of white stone. On a cracked throne sits a figure robed in fading starlight. Its mask of porcelain is shattered, revealing a face that is both ancient and kind. It speaks directly into your mind: 'Three keys. Find them. The Architect wears my fear like a crown. The Crown lies in the Fractured Court. The Heart beats in the Dreaming Depths. Find them before the hollow ones consume everything. Please. I cannot hold on much longer.'"

Each character who touches the gate gains **Dreamsense** (30ft, always active) and a vision of three locations for Books 2-5.

# END OF BOOK 1

Return to Drearym — and a cliffhanger for Book 2

## RESOLUTION

- ◆ Mordath is dying — not trying to harm anyone. His death-throes are the curse.
- ◆ There are **three keys**: The Architect, The Crown, The Heart.
- ◆ The Architect — a fragment of Mordath's own fear — wants the god dead.
- ◆ Brother Caelum and the Dreamseekers are being manipulated.
- ◆ The players are Dreambound — tied to Mordath's fate.

## CLIFFHANGER FOR BOOK 2

"As you leave the Gatehouse, you see them. A vast army of Unbound — hundreds strong — marching toward Drearym. At their head: Brother Caelum, eyes glowing purple, the Architect's symbol burning on his forehead. His 'sharing circle' was a trap. He's been converting Dreambound into Unbound, building an army to storm the Fractured Court and kill Mordath by force."

## TREASURE & REWARDS

- Guardian's Longsword (uncommon, attunement)**  
+1 longsword. Extra 1d4 psychic vs undead/fiends. 1/long rest: *detect thoughts* (DC 13).
- Marta's Gratitude**  
If Lissa rescued: *Potion of Greater Healing* + *Cloak of Elvenkind*. Free lodging for the rest of the campaign.
- Monastery Journal**  
Worth 25gp. DC 15 History reveals location of the Fractured Court (Book 2 starting point).
- Dreambound Sigil**  
Glows permanently. Identify other Dreambound. Advantage on saves vs nightmare effects.

**Milestone:** Party reaches level 3.

## GM NOTES

- Tone:** Waking up in someone else's nightmare. The horror is wrongness. The tragedy is that Mordath is not a villain.
- Moral Complexity:** Neither faction is wrong. Guard wants to preserve Mordath. Dreamseekers want to end the curse. Both conflict with player survival.
- Scaling:** Level 1: Knight HP 60, no Legendary Actions. Level 4+: +2 Nightmare Spawn in Chapel, Knight +10 HP.

## THE HOLLOW DOMINION

A once-prosperous kingdom cursed by the death-throes of Mordath, the Dreaming God. His nightmares leak into the waking world — twisting landscapes, corrupting creatures, and driving the populace mad.

The players are Dreambound — souls tethered to Mordath's fading consciousness. They cannot leave until the curse is broken. But if Mordath dies, they die with him.

From the Ashen Gate to the Gatehouse of Dreams, the party must navigate nightmare-ravaged lands, choose which faction to trust, and find the three keys that can save the Dominion — or doom it forever.

D&D 5e | Levels 1-3 | 3-4 Sessions | 3-5 Players

**by Helm Evans**

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